of polytheism in Mecca, his mission could also be seen as an attempt to unify various clans into one single community by replacing their own family gods with one single God.

The revelation that Muhammad received is what we nowadays call the Qur'an, and Muslims around the world read or recite it every day with the highest esteem. The word *qur'an* in Arabic means reading or recitation. For Muslims, the Qur'an is a word-for-word record of Allah's speeches to Muhammad. The speeches were recited, recorded and later collected as a book by Muhammad's followers. With a total of 114 chapters, the Qur'an is divided into *Suras* (or chapters) of Mecca and *Suras* of Medina (the second city where Muhammad received the revelation). For Muslims, the Qur'an is the most authoritative, greatest and clearest instruction that Allah has given to the world, in which Muslims can find guidance and the road to salvation.

The selected reading here is Sura 2, "The Cow" (黃牛篇). It is the longest in the Qur'an. The reasons for the selection are manifold. First, scholars generally agree that it is the first Medina chapter, which represents the emergence of Islam as a religious and political community. By studying Sura 2, we can analyze the reason why this community came to be, and understand the way of its development, its mission to the world, and expectations placed on its members, i.e. the Muslims. Second, we can also catch a glimpse of the fundamentals of Islam by reading this Sura which outlines some basic Islamic beliefs and duties, including what we now call the Six Articles of Faith (六信) and the Five Pillars (五功). Finally, it discusses the social obligations and rules of this emergent community such as taking up arms for Allah, care of the needy and practices of divorce. While reading it, we can critically re-examine the image of Muslims that is portrayed in the mass media—as associated with violence and male superiority, for example.

The translation of the Qur'an is by Tarif Khalidi, a Muslim professor in Islamic studies, who translated directly from the Arabic scripture.

Andy C. Yu

from

The Qur'an

THE COW

In the name of God,
Merciful to all,
Compassionate to each!

Alif Lam Mim *

[Verses 1–20 are omitted. Men are classified into three groups according to the way they receive Allah's message: the believers, the unbelievers, and those who claim they believe but do not really believers.]

O People! Worship your Lord Who created you as well as those who came before you. Perhaps you will fear Him. [2:21]

It is He Who made the earth a bed for you, the sky a canopy; Who causes water to descend from the sky with which He brings forth fruits as sustenance for you. Do not, therefore, set up any equals to God when you know better.

[* *A glossary of the terms marked with an asterisk is given at the end of the text on p.119.*]

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If you doubt what We revealed to Our servant, bring forth one *sura* like it. And summon your witnesses, any other than God, if you are truthful. But if you do not, and surely you will not, beware of the Fire whose fuel is mankind and stones,
2:24 made ready for the unbelievers.

Proclaim glad tidings to those who have believed and done good deeds: for them there are Gardens beneath which rivers flow. Whenever they are offered its fruits as sustenance, they say: "This is what we were provided with before"—all alike in excellence is their provision.

In these Gardens they have immaculate spouses.
2:25 In them they abide eternally.

God shies not from drawing a parable even from an insect, or else anything large or small.
Those who believe know it is the truth from their Lord.
Those who disbelieve say: "What did God intend by this parable?"
God thereby leads many astray,
And guides many.
But the dissolute alone He leads astray,
They who violate God's covenant after God had established it,
Who sever what God commanded to be joined,
Who sow discord on earth.
2:27 These are the losers.

How can you disbelieve in God when you were once dead, and He granted you life?
He shall cause you to die,
Then He shall resurrect you,
Then to Him you shall return.
It is He Who created for you all that is on earth. Then He ascended to heaven, and arrayed them in seven heavens.
2:29 All-Knowing is He.

And remember when God said to the angels: "I shall appoint a deputy on earth," and they answered: "Will you place therein one who sows discord and sheds blood

while we chant Your praises and proclaim Your holiness?"
God said: "I know what you do not." 2:30

He taught Adam the names of all things. Then He displayed them to the angels and said: "Tell me the names of these things, if you are truthful."

They said: "Glory be to You! We have no knowledge except what You taught us. You! You are All-Knowing, All-Wise." 2:32

God said: "O Adam, reveal to them their names." When Adam revealed their names, God said: "Did I not tell you that I know the Unseen of the heavens and the earth? That I know what you make public and what you hide?" 2:33

And remember when God said to the angels: "Kneel before Adam"; they knelt, all except Satan, who disdained, grew proud and became an unbeliever.

We said: "O Adam, inhabit the Garden, you and your wife. Eat from it in comfort and ease, wherever you wish. But do not come near this tree, or else you will transgress." Satan seduced them away from it, and caused them to leave their earlier abode.

We said: "Go down, an enemy each to each! On earth you will find habitation and a certain term of life." 2:36

And Adam obeyed the words of his Lord, and his Lord pardoned him.
He is Ever-Ready to pardon; He is Compassionate to each.

We said: "Go down from it, all of you. And when My guidance comes to you, whoever follows My guidance, no fear shall fall upon them, nor shall they grieve. But those who disbelieve and call Our wonders lies, these are the people of the Fire, in which they shall abide for ever." 2:39

Children of Israel, remember My bounty which I bestowed upon you.
Fulfil My covenant and I shall fulfil yours. It is Me you should fear!
Believe in that which I have revealed, confirming what you possess.
Do not be the first to blaspheme against it.
Do not sell away My revelations for a paltry sum. It is Me you should revere!
Do not confound truth with falsehood, and knowingly repress the truth.
Offer up prayers; hand out alms; kneel in prayer with those who kneel.

How can you command people to do good and forget yourselves, all the while reciting the Book? Do you not understand?

Seek help in patience and prayer, prayer that is indeed burdensome except for the devout, for those who believe they will meet their Lord, and that to Him they
2:46 shall return.

[Verses 47–66 are omitted. The Children of Israel are called upon to remember the story of their ancestors. It was with God's help that Moses and his fellow Israelites were able to leave Egypt and be free from the persecution of the Pharaoh. God gave Moses the Book and the Criterion as guidance, and was forgiving and compassionate even though the Israelites became evil and disobedient, worshipping the calf as idol, killing their prophets, etc.]

[2:67] Remember when Moses said to his people: "God commands you to slaughter a cow."

They said: "Are you mocking us?"

He said: "God be my refuge that I should traduce His message!"

They said: "Pray to your Lord that He spell out for us what she may be."

He said: "God says it is a cow, neither old nor a heifer, but midway between. So perform what you have been commanded."

They said: "Pray to your Lord that He spell out her colour for us."

He said: "He says it is a yellow cow, very bright in colour, a joy to behold."

They said: "Pray to your Lord that He point her out to us, for cows are all alike to us and we, God willing, shall be guided."

He said: "He says it is a cow neither yoked to plough the earth nor to water the sown, a cow wholesome and all of one colour."

They said: "Now you speak the truth."

2:71 So they slaughtered it, having come close to not doing so.

Remember when you killed a soul, and how you quarrelled about the matter. But God always reveals what you hide.

So We said: "Strike the dead man with a piece of the cow."

This is how God resurrects the dead and reveals His wonders to you; perhaps you will understand.

Then your hearts grew hard,
Becoming like rocks, or even harder;
For among rocks there are some from which streams gush,
And some have cracks from which water flows,

And some which roll down from fear of God.
But God is not unmindful of what you do. 2:74

Do you really expect them to believe in the message sent to you, when a group among them would hear the speech of God and then pervert it, knowingly, after having grasped its meaning?

Thus, when they meet the believers, they tell them: "We believe." But when they meet one another in private, they say: "Do you speak to them of what God has revealed to you so that they dispute with you before your Lord? Have you no understanding?"

Know they not that God knows what they conceal and what they proclaim? 2:77

Among them too are unlettered folk who understand Scripture only as false hopes. But they are living in illusion.

Wretched too are those who write Scripture with their own hands and then claim it to be from God, that they may sell it for a small price!

Woe to them for what their hands have written!

Woe to them for the profit they made! 2:79

They say: "The Fire shall touch us for a few days only."

Say to them: "Have you a compact with God? God does not go back on His pledge. Or do you impute to God that which you know not?"

Rather, he who engenders an evil deed, and his sin engulfs him—these are the inhabitants of the Fire, dwelling therein for ever.

But those who believe and do good works, they are the inhabitants of the Garden, dwelling therein for ever. 2:82

Remember when We made a covenant with the Children of Israel that "You worship none but God; be kind to parents, kinsmen, orphans and the poor; speak kindly to people; perform the prayer and give alms." Then you turned away, all but a few among you, recanting. 2:83

Remember when We made a covenant with you that "You shall not shed one another's blood, nor shall you drive one another out of your homes." You compacted thus and you yourselves stood witness. But there you are, killing one another and

driving one party among you from their homes, joining forces against them in sin and aggression. Yet, if they come to you as captives, you pay their ransom, even though their expulsion was a thing forbidden to you.

Do you then believe in one portion of the Book and disbelieve in another?

What recompense for one who does this but shame in this present life, and on the Day of Resurrection, away to a punishment most dire?

2:85 God is not unmindful of what you do.

Those who have purchased the present life in exchange for the afterlife, for them
2:86 punishment shall not be lightened, nor shall they find any to help them.

We revealed the Book to Moses, and We sent after him messengers in succession; and We granted Jesus son of Mary evident miracles and strengthened him with the Holy Spirit. Whenever a messenger came to you with a message contrary to your whims, did you not grow arrogant, calling some liars and killing others? They said: "Our hearts are shrouded." Rather, God cursed them for their unbelief. Little is their
2:88 faith.

[Verses 89–108 are omitted. The Children of Israel are further criticized for their lack of faith in God's revelations and for worshipping many gods. They were unhappy that God's grace should extend beyond them to reach whomsoever He wills. They would accept only older revelations and prophets, rejecting the new Truth conveyed by later prophets like Jesus and Muhammad.]

Among the People of the Book there are many who wish they could turn you back to unbelief after you have embraced the faith. This they do out of the envy of their souls, and once the truth has become clear to them.
Forgive and pardon—that is, until God reveals His command.
2:109 God has power over all things.

Perform the prayer and hand out alms.
Any good deed you do, laid by for your souls in this life,
You shall surely find with God.
2:110 God sees full well what you do.

They say: "Only Jews and Christians will enter the Garden." Such are their fancies!

Say to them: "Show me your proof if you speak the truth."

Yes, indeed. He who surrenders his face to God in all piety shall receive his reward from his Lord. No fear shall fall upon them, nor shall they grieve. 2:112

The Jews say the Christians count for nothing; the Christians say the Jews count for nothing; yet both recite the Book. The ignorant repeat their statements.

God shall judge between them on the Day of Resurrection regarding that upon which they differ. 2:113

Who is more impious than he who forbids the houses of God's worship from mention of His name, and devotes himself to their destruction? These shall not enter them except in fear. Shame is their lot in this world, and terrible punishment in the next. 2:114

To God belongs the East and the West.
Wherever you turn, there is the face of God.
God is All-Encompassing, All-Knowing.
They say: "God has fathered a child."
Glory be to Him! To Him, rather, belongs all that is in the heavens and on earth.
All mankind obeys Him.
Marvellous Creator of the heavens and the earth!
When He decrees a matter, He merely says to it: "Be!" and it is. 2:117

The ignorant say: "If only God would speak to us! If only a sign would descend upon us!"

This too was said by past generations, word for word. Their minds are much alike.

But We have made clear these signs to a people of firm faith. 2:118

We have sent you with the Truth,
A herald of good tidings,
A bearer of warning.
You are not accountable for the denizens of hell. 2:119

Jews and Christians will not approve of you unless you follow their religion.

Say: "God's guidance is true guidance."

If you follow their whims after the Knowledge which has come to you, you will have in God neither patron nor champion. Those to whom We revealed the Book recite it as it should rightly be recited. They believe in it. But those who
2:121 repudiate it, they are truly lost.

Children of Israel, remember My bounty, and that I preferred you above all mankind. Fear a Day when no soul can atone one whit for another; when no ransom is accepted for it, when no intercession can do it any good, and no helpers are
2:123 at hand.

Remember when his Lord tested Abraham with certain rulings and how Abraham fulfilled them.

God said: "I shall appoint you an exemplar to mankind."

Abraham said: "And also my descendants."

God said: "Evildoers shall not enjoy My covenant."

Remember when We set up the House as a place frequented by mankind, a sanctuary: "Take the station of Abraham as a place of worship." And We thus commanded Abraham and Ishmael: "To sanctify My House for those who circle around it, those who seclude themselves in it and those who bow and prostrate
2:125 themselves in prayer."

Remember when Abraham said: "Lord, make this city a sanctuary and bless its people with sustenance, those of them who believe in God and the Last Day."

God said: "As for him who disbelieves, I shall grant him brief enjoyment and
2:126 then shall consign him to the torment of the Fire, a wretched fate indeed."

Remember when Abraham and Ishmael were raising up the foundations of the House:
"Our Lord, accept this from us,
You are All-Hearing, All-Knowing.
Our Lord, make us surrender ourselves to You,
And from our descendants a nation which surrenders itself to You.

Show us our holy rituals,
And forgive us. You are All-Forgiving, All-Merciful.
Our Lord, send them a messenger, of their number,
Who shall recite to them Your verses,
Teaching them the Book and the Wisdom,
And who shall purify them.
You are the Almighty, the All-Wise." 2:129

Who can wilfully abandon the religion of Abraham unless it be one who makes a fool of himself? We chose Abraham in this world, and in the hereafter he shall be among the righteous. 2:130

Remember when his Lord said to him: "Surrender!" and he said: "I surrender to the Lord of the Worlds." Abraham entrusted his children with this commandment, as did Jacob: "My children, God has chosen the pure religion for you. Depart not from this life except as those who surrender."

Or were you witnesses when death came to Jacob?

When he said to his sons: "Whom will you worship when I am gone?"

They said: "We shall worship your Lord, and the Lord of your fathers Abraham, Ishmael and Isaac: One God. To Him we surrender." 2:133

That was a nation which passed away.
They have earned their reward, and you have earned yours.
You will not be held responsible for what they did. 2:134

They say: "Become Jews or Christians and you will be guided aright."

Say: "Rather, the religion of Abraham, of pristine faith. Nor was he a polytheist."
Say: "We believe in God, and in what was revealed to us,
In what was revealed to Abraham, to Ishmael, to Isaac and Jacob and the Tribes,
In what was revealed to Moses and Jesus,
In what was revealed to prophets by their Lord.
We make no distinction between any of them,
And to Him we surrender." 2:136

If they then believe in what you believe, they are guided aright. If they turn away, it is they who are in discord. God will deal with them on your behalf. He is All-Hearing, All-Knowing.

The hue of God is upon us! And what better hue than God's?
It is Him we worship.

Say: "Do you argue with us concerning God, He being our Lord and your Lord, and we have our works and you have yours, while to Him we remain sincere? Or are you saying that Abraham, Ishmael, Isaac, Jacob and the Tribes were Jews or Christians?"

Say: "Are you more knowledgeable or is God?"
Who is more unjust than he who keeps hidden a testament he has from God?
2:140 God is not unaware of what you do.

That was a nation which passed away.
They have earned their reward, and you have earned yours.
2:141 You will not be held responsible for what they did.

Foolish people shall say: "What turned them away from the direction of prayer they once followed?"

Say: "To God belongs the East and the West. He guides whomsoever He wills
2:142 onto a straight path."

Thus, We have appointed you as a median nation,
To be witnesses for mankind,
And the Prophet to be a witness for you.

And We did not appoint the direction of prayer which you once followed, except to distinguish him who follows the Prophet from him who turns on his heels. This change of direction was indeed a grave matter, except for those whom God has guided. But God would not allow your earlier faith to have been in vain.

2:143 Towards mankind, God is All-Caring, Compassionate to each.

We have seen you turning your face from side to side in the heavens,
So We will now turn you towards a direction that will please you:
Turn your face towards the Sacred Mosque.
Wherever you may be, turn your faces towards it.

Those granted the Book know that this is the truth from their Lord.
God is not unaware of what they do. 2:144

Were you to come to those granted the Book with every kind of manifest proof, they would not follow your direction. Nor will you follow their direction. Nor indeed do some of them follow the direction of others. Were you to follow their whims, after having received Knowledge, you would then be truly unjust.

Those to whom We brought the Book know it as well as they know their own children.

Some of them suppress the truth knowingly.
This is the Truth from your Lord: be not among those who doubt. 2:147

For every community there is a direction towards which it turns;
Therefore, hasten to charitable deeds.
Wherever you may be, God will ultimately gather you in.
God has power over all things.
From any place you leave, turn your face towards the Sacred Mosque.
It is indeed the Truth from your Lord;
God is not unaware of what you do.
From any place you leave, turn your face towards the Sacred Mosque.
In any place you may be, turn your faces towards it,
So that people can have no argument against you, except for the unfair among them.
These you should not fear.
Rather, fear Me, so that I can complete My bounty upon you,
And that you may be guided aright. 2:150

Likewise, We sent among you a messenger, reciting Our verses to you, purifying you,
And teaching you the Book and Wisdom:
Teaching you that which you knew not.
So remember Me and I will remember you. 2:152
Give Me thanks, and do not blaspheme.

O believers, seek help in patience and prayer;
God stands with those who are patient.
Do not say about those who are killed in the cause of God that they are dead;
2:154 They are indeed alive, but you do not perceive them.

We shall be testing you with some fear and famine, with loss of wealth, lives and crops:
But give glad tidings to the patient,
To those who, when calamity strikes;
Say: "We belong to God, and to Him we shall return."
Upon them descend blessings from God and mercy.
2:157 They are guided aright.

Al-Safa and al-Marwa* are among the rites of God. As for him who performs the Greater Pilgrimage to the Sacred House or else the Lesser, no blame shall attach to him if he circumambulates them. He who voluntarily does so, in piety, to him God shall be All-Acknowledging, All-Knowing. Those, however, who suppress what We brought down of evident signs and Guidance, after We have made it clear to mankind in the Book, those God shall curse, and all who curse shall curse them—except for those who repent and reform their conduct and proclaim their faith. These
2:160 I shall forgive. And I am All-Forgiving, Compassionate to each.

Those who blaspheme and die as unbelievers, upon them shall descend the curse of God, of the angels and of all mankind, and under that curse they shall abide eternally. Their torment shall not be lessened, nor shall any defence be accepted from them.

Your God is One God. There is no god but He, Merciful to all, Compassionate
2:163 to each.

In the creation of the heavens and the earth,
In the cycle of night and day,
In ships that plough the sea, to mankind's benefit,
In what God causes to descend from the sky of water,
Giving life to the earth, hitherto dead,

And peopling it with all manner of crawling creatures,
In varying the winds and clouds, which run their course between sky and earth—
In these are signs for people who reflect. 2:164

Among people there are those who, instead of God, attach themselves to peers whom they love as much as they love God. But the faithful love God most. If only the unjust would realize, when they face torment, that all power belongs to God, that God is terrible in punishment! Those who were followed would then disown their followers, they would see the torment, and the links between them would be severed. The followers will say: "If only we could have another chance, we would disown them as they disowned us." Thus will God show them their deeds as deepest remorse. Nor will they ever leave the Fire. 2:167

O mankind, eat what issues from the earth: all is licit and good for you. Do not follow in the footsteps of Satan. He is indeed your manifest enemy. He merely commands you to commit evil and debauchery and to speak about God that which you do not know. 2:169

And when it is said to them: "Follow what God has brought down," they answer: "We would rather follow that which we found our ancestors have practised." How so, when their ancestors understood nothing, nor were rightly guided? The likeness of those who disbelieve is like one who bellows to a creature that cannot give ear to anything save "Come!" or "Go!"
Deaf.
Dumb.
Blind.
They do not understand. 2:171

O believers, eat from the good things We have provided you, and give thanks to God if it is Him you truly worship. He merely made illicit for you carrion, blood, flesh of pig and whatever has been consecrated to other than God. But he who is forced to do so, not in transgression nor in defiance, no sin shall attach to him.

God is All-Forgiving, Compassionate to each. 2:172

Those who suppress what God has revealed of the Book, and sell it for a paltry profit, those shall eat only fire in their bellies. God shall not speak to them on the Day of Resurrection, nor shall He cleanse them. A painful torment awaits them. They are those who bartered error for right guidance, and torment for forgiveness. How patiently will they endure the Fire! This is because God has brought down the Book with the Truth, but they who differ regarding the Book are sunk deep in discord. 2:176

Virtue does not demand of you to turn your faces eastwards or westwards. Virtue rather is:

He who believes in God, the Last Day, the angels, the Book and the prophets;

Who dispenses money, though dear, to kinsmen, orphans, the needy, the traveller, beggars and for ransom;

Who performs the prayer and pays the alms;

Who fulfil their contracts when they contract;

Who are steadfast in hardship, calamity and danger;

These are the true believers.

These are truly pious. 2:177

O believers, retaliation for the slain is ordained upon you:

A free man for a free man, a slave for a slave, a female for a female.

But if a brother is forgiven by another regarding what is ordained, then gracious pardon must be offered, and seemly deliverance of payment made. This is an act of leniency from your Lord and a mercy. Whoever commits aggression thereafter, painful torment awaits him.

The prospect of retaliation saves lives, O you who are possessed of minds—perhaps you will fear God. 2:179

It has been ordained upon you, when death is near to one of you, leaving wealth behind, to make a will in favour of parents and close relatives, impartially. This is incumbent upon the pious. If any person alters it after hearing it, sin will fall upon those who alter it. God is All-Hearing, All-Knowing.

But if a person suspects unfairness or sin from a testator, then brings about harmony among them, no sin shall fall upon him. God is All-Forgiving, Compassionate to each. 2:182

O believers, the fast is ordained upon you, as it was ordained upon those who came before you—perhaps you will fear God—for a number of days. Whoever is sick among you or on a journey, then a number of other days. Upon those who can bear it, a penance: the feeding of a poor person. He who willingly proffers good, this would be better for him. To fast is better for you, if only you knew. The month of Ramadan is the one in which the Qur'an was sent down—right Guidance to mankind, and clear signs of Guidance and Distinction of truth from falsehood. Those among you who witness it, let him fast therein. Whoever is sick or on a journey, then a number of other days.

God desires ease for you, and desires not hardship.

Thus may you fulfil the number of days assigned, magnify God for having guided you, and perhaps you will be thankful.

If My worshippers ask you about Me, I am near.

I answer the prayer of him who prays when he prays to Me.

So let them obey Me, and believe in Me—perhaps they will be guided aright. 2:186

It is licit for you, on a night of fasting, to lie down with your wives. They are as a garment to you, and you are as a garment to them. God knows you used to cheat, but He has turned His face towards you and forgiven you. But now go in and lie with them, and seek what God has foreordained for you, and eat and drink until the white streak of dawn can be distinguished from the black streak. Then complete your fast until night-time. Do not lie with them in periods when you retire for devotional prayers in mosques.

These are the bounds set by God: do not infringe them. Thus does God make clear His signs to mankind—perhaps they will grow pious. 2:187

Do not consume each other's wealth in falsehood, nor argue the matter with judges in order to consume a portion of people's wealth unjustly, knowing well what you are doing. 2:188

They ask you about the new moons.

Say: "They are times appointed for mankind, and for the Pilgrimage." It is not a virtue that you approach houses from their backs. Virtue is to be pious. So approach houses from the front, and fear God—perhaps you will achieve your quest. 2:189

Fight in the cause of God those who fight you, but do not commit aggression: God loves not the aggressors. Slay them wherever you fall upon them, and expel them from where they had expelled you; apostasy by force is indeed more serious than slaying. Do not fight them near the Holy Mosque unless they fight you therein. If they fight you therein, slay them: such is the reward of unbelievers. But if they desist, then God is All-Forgiving, Compassionate to each. Fight them until there is no longer forced apostasy, and the religion is God's. If they desist, no aggression is permitted except against the wicked. A Holy Month will substitute for a Holy Month, and sacrilege calls for retaliation. Whoever commits aggression against you, retaliate against him in the same measure as he committed against you. Fear
2:194 God and know that God stands by the pious.

Spend wealth in the cause of God and do not, with your own hands, hurl yourself
2:195 into destruction. Be generous, for God loves the generous.

Carry out the Greater Pilgrimage and the Lesser, for the sake of God. If fear prevents you, make a sacrificial offering of whatever is ready to hand. Do not shave your heads until your offering reaches its appointed place. For those among you who are ill or are diseased in the head, expiation is set: fasting or else a gift of alms, or sacrifice. When you feel secure, then whoever breaks his state of consecration in the period between the Lesser and the Greater Pilgrimage shall make an offering of whatever is ready to hand. He who has nothing to offer must fast for three days during the Greater Pilgrimage and for seven when you return, making ten full days. This is ordained for one whose family is not present at the Holy Mosque. So fear
2:196 God and know that God is severe in punishment.

The Pilgrimage occurs in familiar months. He who undertakes the Pilgrimage during these months, from him no promiscuity, no vice and no discord is allowed during the Pilgrimage. Whatever good you do is known to God. Lay up stores for yourselves, but the best store is piety. Be pious towards Me, O you who are
2:197 possessed of minds.

No blame attaches to you if you seek bounty from your Lord. When you return from 'Arafat,* remember God at the Holy Shrine. Remember how He guided you

when before you had been astray. Then return by way of the rest of the people, and seek God's forgiveness. God is All-Forgiving, Compassionate to each.

When you have completed your sacred rites, remember God as you remember your own parents, or even more intensely. For among people is one who says: "Lord, give us in this world." But he shall have no share of the life hereafter. Among them are those who say: "Lord, grant us good in this world and good in the world hereafter, and spare us the torment of the Fire." To these shall fall a share of what they earned. God is swift in reckoning. Remember God during days appointed. He who leaves in haste after two days commits no sin; he who tarries commits no sin, provided he is God-fearing. Fear God and be assured that to Him you will ultimately be gathered. 2:202

Among people is one who speaks of this present life in a manner that pleases you. He calls upon God to witness what is in his heart, all the while being the staunchest of enemies. But when he departs, he plies the land in order to corrupt it, destroying cultivation and flocks. God loves not corruption. If it is said to him: "Fear God," he waxes proud of his crime. Let hell suffice him, an evil cradle indeed! 2:206

Among people is one who sells his soul seeking the pleasure of God. God is Tender towards His worshippers. 2:207

O believers! Enter the fold of peace, all of you. Do not follow in the footsteps of Satan, for he is to you a manifest enemy. If you slip after clear signs have been revealed to you, be assured that God is Almighty, All-Wise. Are they really waiting for God to come to them in the shadowy folds of clouds, with His angels, when judgement is pronounced and all revert to God? 2:210

Ask the Children of Israel how many a manifest sign We revealed to them. Whoever traduces the bounty of God after it has come to him—God is severe in punishment. 2:211

[Verses 212–215 are omitted. Mankind is seen as one community. God bestows abundance on whomsoever he wills and guides them to a straight path. To enter the Garden one may first undergo violence and injury, as those before them did. One should share wealth with kinsmen and also the needy.]

Fighting has been prescribed for you, although it is a matter hateful to you.
And yet, for all you know, you may hate something—and it is good for you.
For all you know, you may love something—and it is harmful to you.
2:216 God knows, and you do not know.

They ask you about the Sacred Month: is there fighting in it? Say: "Fighting in it is a grave sin. But obstructing the path to God and blasphemy against Him and the Sacred Mosque, and the expulsion of its inhabitants from it, is a graver sin with God.

"Forcing people into unbelief is a graver sin than slaughter."

They will persist in fighting you until they turn you away from your religion, if they can. He among you who retracts his religion and dies an unbeliever, these are people whose works shall come to nothing in this world and the next. These are
2:217 the people of the Fire, in which they shall abide for ever.

Those who believed, and those who emigrated and exerted themselves in the path of God—these can indeed expect the mercy of God. God is All-Forgiving,
2:218 Compassionate to each.

They ask you about wine and gambling.

Say: "In them both lies grave sin, though some benefit, to mankind. But their sin is more grave than their benefit."

They ask you what they shall spend.

Say: "The surplus of possessions."

Thus does God make clear His signs to you. Perhaps you will reflect, in this world and the next.

They ask you about orphans.

Say: "Probity in what concerns them is a virtue.

"Should you associate with them, they are your brothers.

"God knows the dishonest from the honest. Had God willed, He could have
2:220 caused you hardship." God is Almighty, All-Wise.

Do not marry polytheistic women unless they believe. A female slave, who is a

believer, is better than a polytheistic woman, even if winning your admiration. Do not give in marriage to polytheists unless they believe. A male slave who is a believer is better than a polytheistic man, even if winning your admiration. These people will lead you to the Fire, but God leads to the Garden and forgiveness, by His leave.

He makes clear His signs to mankind; perhaps they will remember and reflect. 2:221

They ask you about menstruation.

Say: "It is a sore. So keep away from women in menstruation, and do not come near them until they become clean. When clean, approach them from where God ordered you."

God loves those who constantly repent, who constantly cleanse themselves.

Your women are your sowing field: approach your field whenever you please. Lay up good works for yourselves and fear God, and know that you shall surely meet Him. Proclaim glad tidings to the believers. 2:222

Do not make an oath by God an excuse for you not to do good works, to fear God or to act honourably towards people. God is All-Hearing, All-Knowing. God does not hold you to account for carelessness in pronouncing oaths, but He holds you to account for what your hearts have earned. God is All-Forgiving, All-Forbearing. 2:225

For those who forsake their wives is prescribed a waiting period of four months. If they go back on their oath, God is All-Forgiving, Compassionate to each. If they are determined on divorce, God is All-Hearing, All-Knowing. Divorced women shall refrain from remarriage for three menstrual cycles. Nor is it licit for them to hide what God has created in their wombs, if they truly believe in God and the Last Day. Meanwhile, their husbands have a better right to take them back if they desire reconciliation. Women have the selfsame rights and obligations in conformity with fairness, but men are a grade more responsible than them. God is Almighty, All-Wise. 2:228

Divorce can be uttered twice, to be followed either by holding her back in friendship or letting her go in fairness. It is not licit for you to take back anything you have given them unless the two of them fear that they cannot conform to the bounds of God. If you fear that the two of them will not conform to the bounds of God, no blame attaches to them both if the woman gives back that with which she sets herself

free. These are the bounds set by God; do not transgress them. Whoso transgresses the bounds of God, these are indeed sinners. If he divorces her, she shall not be licit to him again until she marries another husband. If the other husband divorces her, no blame attaches to them if they return to each other, provided they believe they can conform to the bounds of God.

And these are the bounds of God, which He makes plain to people who
2:230 understand.

If you divorce women, and they reach their appointed term, hold them back in amity or let them go in amity. Do not hold them back out of malice, to be vindictive. Whoso does this does himself an injustice. Do not treat the revelations of God as matters for jesting. Remember the bounties of God upon you and what He revealed to you of the Book and Wisdom, wherewith He edifies and instructs you. Fear God
2:231 and know that God is Omniscient.

If you divorce women, and they reach their appointed term, do not deter them from marrying their former husbands, provided they both freely agree to do so, and in an affable manner. Through this commandment are edified and instructed those among you who believe in God and the Last Day. This would be better for you and more pure in heart.

2:232 God knows and you do not know.

Mothers nurse their infants two full years for one who desires to complete the course of nursing. Upon the father rests the duty of maintenance and clothing, affably granted.

No soul is burdened except with what it can bear.

No mother is to be harmed through her child, nor father through his.

The same duty rests upon the heir.

If the two of them desire to wean their child through mutual agreement and consultation, no blame attaches to them. If you wish to deliver your children to a wet-nurse, no blame attaches to you provided you pay what you have agreed upon, fairly and affably.

2:233 Fear God and know that God sees all that you do.

As for those among you who die and leave wives behind, their widows are to hold themselves apart for a period of four months and ten nights. When they reach their appointed term, no blame shall attach to you regarding what they might honourably do with themselves. God is All-Experienced as to what you do. Nor shall any blame attach to you if you allude to a marriage proposal with these widows or else keep this to yourselves. God knows that you shall propose to them. But do not make promises to them in secret, unless it be in fair and honourable speech. Do not tie the knot of marriage until the recorded period has reached its term.

Know that God knows what is in your hearts. So fear Him and know that God is All-Forgiving, All-Forbearing. 2:235

No blame attaches to you if you divorce women, not having touched them yet or settled any marriage settlement upon them. But provide for them—a rich man what he can bear and a poor man what he can bear. Let this be provided fairly and affably, and let this be an obligation upon men of good conduct. But if you divorce them, not having touched them yet though having settled upon them a marriage settlement, then half of what you settled, unless they forgo this right or else he who holds the knot of marriage in his hand forgoes it. Yet, if you forgo this right, it would be nearer to piety.

Do not forget to be generous one to another. God sees all that you do. 2:237

Perform your prayers regularly and the afternoon prayer, and stand in God's presence in humility and devotion. But if you are in a state of fear, then pray while walking or mounted. When again you feel secure, remember God and how He taught you that which you knew not. 2:239

Those among you who die leaving wives behind are to leave a bequest to their wives: maintenance for a year and no eviction. If they leave, then no blame attaches to you regarding what they do with themselves, if they do so honourably.

God is Almighty, All-Wise. 2:240

For divorced women, maintenance is decreed, fair and affable. This is an obligation upon the pious. Thus does God make plain His revelations to you; perhaps you will understand. 2:242

[Verses 243–255 are omitted. Those who fight in the cause of God will be rewarded many times over. The story of Moses continued, followed by references to Saul and Jesus. Notable Israelites had asked for a king who would lead them to fight in the cause of God; yet when God gave them Moses, all but a few turned away from fighting. The king Saul tested his army's faith by telling them God forbids their drinking from a river they will pass by; only a few passed the test, among whom, David was steadfast enough to triumph over Goliath and was rewarded with kingship and wisdom. God bestowed wonders on Jesus son of Mary and strengthened him with the Holy Spirit; but people fell into discord after he came. The verses end with a distinction between unbelievers and believers and a praise of God.]

There is no compulsion in religion.
Right guidance has been distinguished from error.
He who repudiates idols and believes in God
Has grasped a handle most firm, unbreakable.
2:256 God is All-Hearing, All-Knowing.

God is the Patron of the believers:
He leads them from the folds of darkness to the light.
As for the unbelievers, their patrons are the idols:
They lead them from the light to the folds of darkness.
2:257 These are the people of the Fire, in which they abide for ever.

[Verses 258–260 are omitted. Granted kingship by God, Abraham shows good faith in God as giver of life and dealer of death. Witness is given of God's being the omnipotent one, who brought to life even birds that Abraham had cut into pieces.]

[2:261] The likeness of those who spend their wealth in the cause of God is like a grain which brought forth seven ears, in each ear a hundred grains. God multiplies His bounty to whomsoever He pleases. And God is All-Generous, All-Knowing. Those who spend their wealth in the cause of God, and do not follow up what they spent by demanding gratitude or causing offence, shall have their reward with their Lord.
2:262 No fear shall fall upon them, nor shall they grieve.

A kind word followed by magnanimity is better than charity followed by rudeness.
God is All-Sufficient, All-Forbearing. 2:263

O believers, nullify not your alms-giving by demanding gratitude or causing offence, like one who spends his wealth in order to flaunt it before people but believes neither in God nor in the Last Day. His likeness is like a boulder upon which is some earth. A downpour strikes it, leaving it hard and smooth. Such people can do nothing with what they have earned. God guides not the impious.

But the likeness of those who spend their wealth, desiring the pleasure of God and to fortify their own faith, is like a garden upon a hill. A downpour strikes it and it produces double its harvest; if not a downpour, then a mere shower. God sees full well all that you do. Would any of you wish to have a garden of palm trees and vines, beneath which rivers flow, and in which he has all kinds of fruit, and then old age overtakes him, and he has heirs who are minors—now a fiery tempest batters it and it burns down? Thus does God make clear His signs; perhaps you will reflect. 2:266

O believers, expend from the good things that you have earned, and from what We brought forth for your benefit from the earth. Do not give in alms the inferior portion thereof, since you yourselves would not accept such unless you turn a blind eye to it. Know that God is All-Sufficient, All-Praiseworthy. Satan promises you poverty and commands you to commit sin; God promises you forgiveness from Him and bounty. God is All-Encompassing, Omniscient. 2:268

He grants wisdom to whomsoever He wills,
And he to whom wisdom is granted has been granted abundant good.
But none remembers except the prudent. 2:269

Whatever sum you spend,
Whatever vow you take,
All is known to God.
The unjust shall have no champions. 2:270

If you make public your gifts, freely given, that would be worthy. But if you conceal them and donate them to the poor, that would be even better for you. God
2:271 will thereby pardon your sins. God is All-Experienced with what you do.

It is not up to you to guide them. It is God, rather, Who guides whomsoever He wills.

Whatever good you expend is for your own souls. Do not expend anything except to seek the pleasure of God, and whatever good you expend will be paid back to you; you shall not be wronged. It should go to the poor, those who are constrained in the cause of God and are unable to journey in the land: an ignorant person would think them rich because of their self-restraint. You will recognize them by their outward appearance. They do not importune people. Whatever good you expend,
2:273 God knows it well.

Those who spend their wealth, night and day, in secret or in public, shall have their reward with their Lord. No fear shall fall upon them, nor shall they grieve.

Those who consume usury shall not rise from the dead except like one whom Satan causes to babble from madness. This is because they allege that commerce is the same as usury. But God has made commerce licit and usury illicit. So he to whom a word of counsel from his Lord has reached, and desists, may keep his previous profit, and his affair is up to God. But he who relapses, these are the inhabitants of the Fire, in which they dwell eternally. God annuls usury and augments free gifts.
2:276 God loves not every impious lawbreaker.

Those who believe, do good deeds, perform their prayers and offer alms shall have their reward with their Lord. No fear shall fall upon them, nor shall they
2:277 grieve.

O believers, fear God and abandon what remains of usury if you are true believers. If you do not, be forewarned of conflict with God and His Messenger. If you repent, you will keep the capital of your wealth, neither wronging nor wronged. If a person is in difficulties, let there be respite until a time of ease. And if you give freely, it

would be better for you, if only you knew. Fear a Day in which you shall return to God, when each soul shall be paid back that which it has earned. And they shall not be wronged. 2:281

O believers, if you contract a debt among yourselves for a set term, write it down. Let a scribe write it down in your presence, in all fairness. Let no scribe refrain from writing as God has taught him. So let him write, and let the debtor dictate. Let him fear God, his Lord, and let him not reduce a jot from it. If the debtor is foolish or feeble or is unable to dictate, let his guardian dictate, in all fairness. Summon two witnesses from among your men. If two men are not at hand, then a man and two women from witnesses of whom you approve. If one woman forgets, the one will remind the other. Nor should witnesses be reluctant if summoned. And do not be reluctant to write it down, whether small or large, up to its set term, for this is fairer in God's eyes, more equitable for testimony, and less cause for you to be distrustful. However, if it concerns an immediate commercial deal that you transact among yourselves, no blame attaches to you if you do not write it down. If you trade with one another, summon witnesses and let no scribe or witness come to any harm. If you do them harm, this would be an offence on your part. Fear God and God will instruct you. And God is Omniscient. 2:282

If you are on a journey and do not find a scribe, let there be a surety handed over. If you trust one another, let the trustee fulfil his trust and let him fear God, his Lord. And do not conceal testimony; whoever conceals it, his heart is sinful and God knows full well what you do. 2:283

To God belongs all that is in the heavens and all that is on earth. Whether you reveal what lies in your souls or whether you conceal it, God will hold you to account, forgiving whomever He wills and punishing whomever He wills. God is Omnipotent. 2:284

The Messenger believes in what was revealed to him from his Lord, as do the believers. All believe in God, His angels, His Books and His messengers. We make no distinction between any of His messengers. They say: "We hear and obey. We await Your forgiveness, O Lord. To You is the journey's end."

God charges not any soul except with what it can bear. To its credit belongs what it has earned: upon it falls the burden of what it has deserved.
Our Lord,
Take us not to task if we forget or err.
Our Lord,
Do not lay upon us a heavy burden, as You laid upon those who came before us.
Our Lord,
Do not lay upon us what we have no power to bear.
Pardon us, forgive us, be merciful towards us.
2:286 You are our Patron, so grant us Your support against the impious.

GLOSSARY

Alif Lam Mim Twenty-nine chapters of the Qur'an begin with the names of Arabic letters in various combinations. These are the so-called 'mysterious letters' of the Qur'an whose meaning, according to most exegetes, is best left with God.

'Arafat The name of a plain and hill to the east of Mecca, central to the rite of pilgrimage.

Harut and Marut Mysterious fallen angels of Babylon and teachers of sorcery.

Sabeans An ancient Near Eastern religious community considered by the Qur'an to belong to the **People of the Book**.

al-Safa and al-Marwa Two hills adjoining the Ka'ba of Mecca, a square structure in the middle of the Meccan sanctuary and the centre of Muslim pilgrimage and devotions.

People of the Book Arabic *Ahl al-Kitab*; a Qur'anic term denoting religious communities to whom a divine scripture had been revealed. These include Jews, Christians, **Sabeans** and Magians.